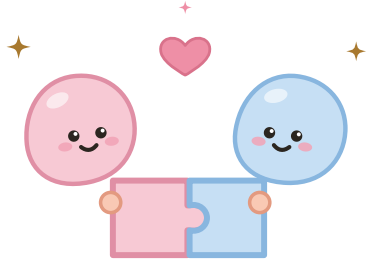
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · A POCKET GUIDE

The Logic Behind It

A Pocket Guide to Why People React the Way They Do



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

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If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The situations in this guide are drawn from common patterns, and nobody in them is a real person; any likeness is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the pages lean on is listed in short at the back, and in full at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

Contents

How to use this guide 4

Why a reaction can look odd 5

The six parts 6

It runs both ways 7

Logic explains. It doesn't excuse. 8

1 Plans and change 9
4 situations

2 Sensory and energy 14
5 situations

3 Talking and literal meaning 20
5 situations

4 Social rules 26
5 situations

5 Work and school 32
4 situations

6 Family and partners 37
5 situations

7 Feelings and shutdowns 43
4 situations

8 Routines and special interests 48
2 situations

9 Different rulebooks 51
4 situations

Build your own 56

Find it fast 61

More, free online 63

Research notes 64

The series 66

Your notes 67

How to use this guide

Thirty-eight everyday reactions, one to a page. Each page walks through the same six parts, so after a few you'll start to see the logic in reactions this guide never mentions.

- **Dip in anywhere.** Each page stands on its own. Use the contents, the section pages or "Find it fast" at the back to go straight to the situation in front of you.
- **Read it with the other person.** A page can say what is hard to say in the moment. Hand it over, or read it together, and talk about the last two parts, the other side and the small step.
- **Use it both ways.** Some pages may explain you, and some may explain the people around you. Either way, the aim is a fair view of both sides.
- **Scan for more.** Each page has a code to the same situation on the website, free, with more pictures to choose from. The website has more than seventy situations and a box where you can type your own.
- **Build your own.** The blank cards at the back walk you through the six parts for a reaction this guide doesn't cover.

THE SIX-PART LENS

Why a reaction can look odd

A friend leaves the party without a goodbye. A colleague's feedback lands like a slap. Someone says "I'm fine" when they plainly aren't. Seen from outside, each of these can look odd, rude or over the top.

Most of them have a logic behind them. It makes sense once you can see it, and it is usually a sensible answer to how someone is built, what they learned and what kind of day they've had. The trouble is that the logic is hidden, so other people fill the gap with a guess, and the guess is often unkind.

This guide puts the logic into words, one step at a time, so the reaction can be understood. It also gives the other person a fair way to respond, because every page includes their side too.

No page is a diagnosis or a label. People differ, and no group always does anything. The pages say "many people" or "some people" on purpose.

THE SIX-PART LENS

The six parts

Take one reaction, yours or someone else's, and walk through six parts.

1. **What it looks like.** One line in camera words, what a camera would see or hear. There is no "rude" and no "weird", because a verdict closes the question before the logic can answer it.
2. **The logic.** Three or four short steps, each following from the one before. The chain starts with a plain fact about how things work, such as "Energy works like a budget".
3. **It's like.** An everyday picture that works the same way inside. A phone on 3% shuts down the extras to protect the call, which is why it suits low energy so well.
4. **Why it fits.** What makes the reaction reasonable, said fairly and without stretching it. Where research supports a page, the research notes at the back list it.
5. **The other side.** What the other person may have felt or needed. This part keeps the lens fair, so nobody has to be the bad guy.
6. **One sentence and one step.** Words you could actually say out loud, and a step small enough to try this week that helps both people.

The order matters. Seeing the logic first makes the other side easier to hear, and the small step comes last, once both sides are on the table.

THE SIX-PART LENS

It runs both ways

Every situation carries one of three small tags.

COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

a reaction many neurodivergent people have, explained for people who don't share it, such as headphones at dinner or a long talk about one interest.

A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

a habit many people find natural, explained in plain logic for anyone who finds it baffling, such as small talk, "I'm fine" and hints.

SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

a reaction anyone can have, such as snapping when hungry or going quiet in a row.

The tag says where a reaction is common. It never tells you what the person in front of you is.

The pages about common social habits matter as much as the others. If you have ever been told you "should have known" what someone meant, it can be a relief to see that there was a system all along, and that it can be learned or simply asked about. And if you use those habits without thinking, seeing their logic written down shows where someone else might miss the signal.

The last section, "Different rulebooks", is about habits learned in a particular place, family or generation. Two people can each be polite by their own rules and still upset each other.

THE SIX-PART LENS

Logic explains. It doesn't excuse.

Knowing why a reaction happened doesn't make its effects disappear. If a reaction hurts someone, the kind and logical next step is to say so, put it right and find a better step for next time.

Some pages have a line marked "With care". It appears where a reaction can land hard on someone else, and it says what keeps things fair.

Seeing the other side doesn't mean agreeing to everything the other person wants. A "no" or a limit given with care is part of looking after a relationship.

If you're reading a page with someone, start with the part about their side. People listen more easily once they feel understood.

SECTION 1

Plans and change

Last-minute changes, surprises, lateness, and what "sometime" means.

A plan does more than fix a time. For many people it is a map of the day, already walked through in the mind. When it changes at short notice, or was never quite made, the map has to be redrawn. These pages look at what that costs, and at the friendly plans that were never meant to happen at all.

1 Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute 10

2 Running late again, despite really caring 11

3 "Let's get coffee sometime" with no date 12

4 "Maybe" that means no 13



1 PLANS AND CHANGE · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The plan changes an hour before, and the person goes quiet, tense or upset, even though the new plan sounds fine.

THE LOGIC

1. A plan is a map the mind has already walked through
2. A late change means redrawing the map with no warning
3. Redrawing uses the energy that was meant for the day itself
4. The upset is the cost of the redraw, not a verdict on the new plan

IT'S LIKE

A sat nav recalculating while you're already on the motorway. For a moment it has no route at all.

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, and for many anxious people, not knowing what comes next is costly in itself. A plan lowers that cost. Losing it at short notice is a real loss of something that was holding the day together.

THE OTHER SIDE

The other person may have seen the change as small, or even as a nice surprise. They may feel their good intention was missed, or worry they can never change anything.

> **"I'm not against the new plan. I just need a few minutes to catch up with the change."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Give changes as early as you can, with the reason. The person who needs time says "Give me ten minutes and I'll be on board," and then comes back on board.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=plan-changed

Running late again, despite really caring

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone who clearly cares about you arrives late, again, with an apology.

THE LOGIC

1. For some minds, time has only two settings, “now” and “not now”
2. “Not now” turns into “now” all at once
3. Getting ready takes longer than the mind guessed
4. Lateness is a clock problem, not a caring problem

IT’S LIKE

A *watch with only two settings, “plenty of time” and “too late”.*

WHY IT FITS

For many people with ADHD, sensing time passing is genuinely harder. Researchers describe it as part of how attention and self-control work. It says nothing about how much someone cares.

THE OTHER SIDE

Waiting can feel like being less important, and it costs the other person real time and sometimes money. Repeated lateness can wear down trust.

> **“I misjudge time. You matter to me, and I’m working on it.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Set an alarm for the time to leave rather than the time to arrive, and text “Leaving now” when you go. The waiting person can agree a time to start without them.
>
> WITH CARE Logic explains lateness; it doesn’t make the other person’s time free. A real fix (alarms, leaving earlier, a text) shows the care that the lateness hides.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=late-again

“Let’s get coffee sometime” with no date

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone says “We should get coffee sometime!” and then never sets a day.

THE LOGIC

1. The phrase is a friendly signal rather than a booking
2. It says “I like you and I’m open to more”
3. A fixed date would turn it into a commitment neither of you has checked
4. Leaving it vague keeps it warm and low-pressure for both

IT’S LIKE

A *wave across the street. It means “hello, I see you”, not “come over”.*

WHY IT FITS

Many people use loose invitations to show warmth without putting anyone on the spot. Either person can turn it into a real plan later, or let it rest without anyone losing face.

THE OTHER SIDE

Someone who takes words literally hears a plan, waits for it, and then feels let down when nothing happens. It can feel like a broken promise.

> **“When I say ‘sometime’, I mean I’d like to. If you want a real date, ask me for one and I’ll say yes or no.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP If you want it to happen, ask “Shall we pick a day?” If you said “sometime” and don’t mean it yet, don’t worry. The other person can ask too.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=coffee-sometime

“Maybe” that means no

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone answers an invitation with “Maybe, I’ll see,” and everyone else seems to know they won’t come.

THE LOGIC

1. A flat “no” can feel like a door shut in someone’s face
2. “Maybe” lets the other person down slowly
3. Both people keep their dignity, because nobody was refused out loud
4. Many listeners hear the no inside the maybe

IT’S LIKE

A *dimmer switch instead of a light switch. The light still goes off, just gently.*

WHY IT FITS

Indirect answers are a common way to say something awkward while keeping the relationship safe. Researchers describe this kind of speech as a way for both people to avoid an open refusal.

THE OTHER SIDE

For someone who takes words at face value, a “maybe” leaves a real question open. They plan around it, wait for an answer, and later feel misled.

> **“I say ‘maybe’ when I don’t want to hurt your feelings. I’ll try to give you a clear yes or no.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP It’s fair to ask kindly, “Is that a maybe-yes or a maybe-no?” And a clear “No, but thank you” is kinder than it sounds.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=maybe-means-no

SECTION 2

Sensory and energy

Noise, touch, crowds, tiredness and hunger, and leaving early.

Noise, crowds, hunger and a long week all draw on the same supply. When it runs low, people leave early, reach for headphones or snap at a small question. These pages follow the logic of a battery that is running down, and what helps before it reaches empty.

5 Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye 15

6 Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people 16

7 Snapping when hungry or tired 17

8 Cancelling plans after a long week 18

9 Needing time alone after seeing people 19



Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Partway through the party, someone slips out with a quick wave, or with no goodbye at all.

THE LOGIC

1. Energy is a budget
2. The party spent it faster than expected
3. Staying past zero risks a shutdown or a sharp word
4. Leaving quietly protects the evening and the friendship

IT'S LIKE

A *phone at 3% switching off everything but the call.*

WHY IT FITS

A long goodbye costs energy too, with a round of hugs and small talk at the door. For people who find social time draining, including many autistic people, the quiet exit still leaves them able to get home safely.

THE OTHER SIDE

The host may feel unappreciated or worry something went wrong. Friends may not know whether the person was upset.

> **"I had a good time. When my battery is gone I need to go quickly, before it runs out completely."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Send a short text afterwards, such as "Thanks for tonight, I had to go when my battery ran out." Hosts can say up front, "Slip out whenever you need to."

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=left-party

6 SENSORY AND ENERGY · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

At a family meal or in the office, someone has headphones or earplugs in.

THE LOGIC

1. Sound arrives whether you want it or not
2. A brain that filters less hears all of it at once
3. Filtering by hand uses up attention
4. Headphones do the filtering, so attention is left for people

IT'S LIKE

Sunglasses on a bright day. You still see everything, just without squinting.

WHY IT FITS

Many autistic people, and many people with ADHD or a sensitive nervous system, take in more of the background. Some researchers think this is partly about how much the brain predicts and smooths out what it hears. Turning the volume down can be what makes staying possible.

THE OTHER SIDE

The people around may feel shut out, or think the person doesn't want to talk to them.

> **"These help me stay at the table. Tap my arm and I'm all yours."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a signal, such as a tap or a wave, that means "I'm talking to you." Where you can, lower the noise for everyone, with the music down and one conversation at a time.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=headphones

Snapping when hungry or tired

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A small question at the end of a long day gets a sharp, short answer.

THE LOGIC

1. Patience runs on fuel
2. Hunger and tiredness drain the tank
3. With an empty tank, small things feel big
4. The snap is the fuel gauge talking, not a verdict on you

IT'S LIKE

A *phone on 3% that suddenly starts closing apps.*

WHY IT FITS

Studies link poor sleep with more conflict between partners the next day, and suggest hunger can colour how harshly we judge things, especially when we don't notice we're hungry. The snap is real information about the body's state.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person who asked did nothing wrong. A sharp tone still lands on them, and it can make them feel like they have to tiptoe.

> **"I'm running on empty. It's not about you. Can we talk after I've eaten?"**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Name the state before you answer ("I'm wiped"), eat or rest, then come back and repair. Keep big topics away from the hungry, tired times of day.
>
> WITH CARE Explaining the snap doesn't undo it. A quick "Sorry I snapped, I was starving" after the snack is part of the logic working properly.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hungry-tired-snap

8 SENSORY AND ENERGY · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Cancelling plans after a long week

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

On Friday afternoon a text arrives. “So sorry, I can’t make tonight.”

THE LOGIC

1. Energy recharges with rest
2. This week spent all of it
3. Going out at zero means being there in body but not in mind
4. Cancelling spares the friendship a flat, tired evening

IT’S LIKE

Not driving when you’re too tired to drive safely.

WHY IT FITS

Rest is what makes good company possible. Sometimes the kindest thing a tired person can offer is a better evening later.

THE OTHER SIDE

The friend may have cleared their own evening, booked a table or been looking forward to it. Last-minute cancelling can feel like they come last.

> **“I’m empty, not uninterested. Can we pick a new day now?”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Cancel as early as you can and offer a new date in the same message. If it keeps happening, plan lighter evenings, like a walk or a takeaway at home.
>
> WITH CARE Cancelling often, or at the last minute, does cost the other person. Saying so and offering a real alternative keeps it fair.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=cancel-tired

Needing time alone after seeing people

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

After visitors leave, the person heads straight to another room and shuts the door.

THE LOGIC

1. Time with people can be lovely and still costly
2. The cost has to be paid back
3. Quiet time is how it gets paid back
4. After it, the person comes back recharged

IT'S LIKE

Wringing out a sponge so it can soak up more.

WHY IT FITS

People recover from social time at different speeds. For many introverted people, many autistic people and many people who mask, quiet after company is how they recover, not a sign the company was bad.

THE OTHER SIDE

A partner or host may feel shut out just when they wanted to chat about how it went, or wonder if they did something wrong.

> **"I had a good time. I need an hour on my own, then I'd love to hear what you thought."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a recharge time after visits, with a time to come back together, such as a cup of tea at eight.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=alone-after-people

SECTION 3

Talking and literal meaning

Blunt words, literal answers, hints, "I'm fine" and teasing.

The same words can carry a plain meaning and a hidden one. Some people say exactly what they mean and hear exactly what is said. Others hint, soften and tease, and expect the hidden meaning to be heard. Both are systems, and either one can be learned, or simply asked about.

10 Giving blunt, direct feedback 21

11 Saying "I'm fine" when you're not 22

12 Hinting instead of asking 23

13 Teasing as a sign of affection 24

14 Not looking at you while listening 25



10 TALKING AND LITERAL MEANING · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Giving blunt, direct feedback

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

You ask for an opinion and get it straight. "The second half doesn't work."

THE LOGIC

1. The goal is to help the work be right
2. Soft words can hide the point
3. A clear point is quicker to fix
4. Being direct is a way of respecting your time

IT'S LIKE

A *sat nav says "Turn left", not "You might like to consider left at some point."*

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, saying what they mean plainly is the honest, respectful option. Research on the "double empathy problem" suggests mix-ups between differently wired people run both ways, so the plain speaker isn't the only one missing signals.

THE OTHER SIDE

Words land on feelings as well as facts. The other person may have put a lot into the work and feel dismissed or attacked.

> **"I'm direct because I trust you with the real answer. I'm on your side."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Add one warm line before the fact, such as "There's a lot here I like." The listener can ask for it too. "Start with one thing that works, then tell me straight."
>
> WITH CARE If plain words keep hurting someone, the kind, logical move is to add the warm line, because the point lands better when the person isn't bracing.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=blunt

Saying “I’m fine” when you’re not

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone is clearly having a hard day but answers every question with “I’m fine.”

THE LOGIC

1. Feelings shared in passing can be too much to unpack right now
2. “Fine” closes the topic politely for now
3. It protects the moment in the queue, the meeting or the school run
4. It often means “not here, not now” rather than “never”

IT’S LIKE

A “*Back in 10 minutes*” *sign, closed for now and open again later.*

WHY IT FITS

“Fine” is a widely understood way to keep a hard feeling private until there is time and space for it. It lets the day keep moving without lying about anything important later.

THE OTHER SIDE

People who take words literally believe it, then get blamed for not noticing. Others feel shut out, or keep asking and seem to pry.

> **“When I say ‘fine’, sometimes I mean ‘not now’. I’ll try to say ‘later’ instead.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Swap “fine” for “Not now, later tonight?” The other person can ask “Now or later?” instead of “What’s wrong?”

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=im-fine

Hinting instead of asking

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"It's a bit cold in here," someone says, and seems annoyed when nobody closes the window.

THE LOGIC

1. A direct request can sound like an order
2. A hint offers the idea without pressure
3. The other person can say yes as if it were their own idea, or not
4. Both people avoid an open "no"

IT'S LIKE

Leaving a door ajar rather than pushing someone through it.

WHY IT FITS

Researchers who study indirect speech argue that hints let people make requests while leaving everyone room to decline without embarrassment. It is a way of being polite.

THE OTHER SIDE

Hints get missed by many people, and not only by autistic people. The hinter then feels ignored, and the other person feels blamed for something nobody actually asked.

> **"When I hint, I'm trying to be gentle. I'll say what I need out loud."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Add the ask to the hint. "It's cold. Could you close the window?" The listener can check, "Would you like me to close it?"



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hints

Teasing as a sign of affection

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Friends call each other names and laugh, and seem closer for it.

THE LOGIC

1. Teasing says "we're close enough to joke"
2. The mock insult works because both know it isn't true
3. The shared laugh confirms the bond
4. It's a test of closeness that both pass together

IT'S LIKE

Puppies play-fighting. The teeth never close.

WHY IT FITS

In many friendships and families, gentle teasing is a ritual that shows trust. Both people know where the line is, and the joke reminds them they share that knowledge.

THE OTHER SIDE

Someone who takes words literally, or who was teased unkindly in the past, may hear only the insult. It can sting, and they may not feel able to say so.

> **"When I tease you, it's because I feel close to you. If it ever stings, tell me and I'll stop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Check now and then with "Was that okay?" Agree what is off limits, and stop any joke that keeps landing as hurt.
>
> WITH CARE Teasing that keeps hurting isn't working as affection, whatever was meant. The logical step is to stop that joke.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=teasing

14 TALKING AND LITERAL MEANING · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Not looking at you while listening

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

While you talk, the person looks at the table, the window or their hands.

THE LOGIC

1. Eyes carry a huge amount of information
2. Taking in a face and words at once splits attention
3. Looking away frees attention for the words
4. Not looking can mean listening harder

IT'S LIKE

Closing your eyes to hear the music better.

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, eye contact is uncomfortable or uses up the attention they need for listening. Studies find non-autistic people often judge autistic people quickly on style like this, even when what was said is just as good.

THE OTHER SIDE

Many people learn that eye contact means "I'm with you". Without it they may feel ignored or think the person is bored or hiding something.

> **"I'm listening. Looking away helps me hear you properly."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Check understanding with words instead of eyes, with the listener summing up one line of what they heard. Hard talks can happen side by side, on a walk or in the car.

This one online
Free, with more pictures to choose from.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=no-eye-contact

SECTION 4

Social rules

Small talk, white lies, "How are you?", sorry, goodbyes, and masking.

Small talk, white lies and "How are you?" can look pointless from outside. Each one does a quiet job, such as showing goodwill or sparing a feeling. These pages lay out those jobs in plain steps, along with the cost of keeping up appearances all day.

15 Small talk about the weather 27

16 A white lie about a present 28

17 "How are you?" when nobody wants a full answer 29

18 A goodbye that takes half an hour 30

19 Fine all day, then falling apart at home 31



15 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

Small talk about the weather

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Two people who barely know each other spend five minutes on the weather and the traffic.

THE LOGIC

1. Strangers need a safe way to check each other out
2. The weather is a topic with no risk in it
3. Swapping easy lines shows "I'm friendly, you can relax"
4. Once both feel safe, real talk can start

IT'S LIKE

Musicians tuning up before the concert. There's no tune yet, but it makes the tune possible.

WHY IT FITS

Small talk isn't really about information. It's a way to show goodwill and build a little trust. Studies suggest brief, friendly chats, even with people we hardly know, are linked with feeling more connected and with better days.

THE OTHER SIDE

For people who find it pointless or tiring, including many autistic people, it costs energy and gives no new information. They may wonder why everyone pretends to care about rain.

> **"Small talk is how I say hello and check we're friendly. It doesn't have to be about the weather for long."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Have two easy lines ready and one real question ("What's keeping you busy at the moment?"). It's fine to steer to a topic you care about after a minute.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=small-talk

16 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A white lie about a present

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone unwraps a jumper they will never wear and says “I love it!”

THE LOGIC

1. The gift is a message that says “I thought of you”
2. The truth about the jumper would answer the wrong message
3. “I love it” answers the care, not the wool
4. The small untruth protects the bond

IT’S LIKE

Thanking a child for a drawing that looks nothing like you.

WHY IT FITS

Many people see small, kind untruths as part of being warm. Studies find that lies told to spare someone’s feelings can actually make people trust the teller’s kindness more, though less so their honesty.

THE OTHER SIDE

For people who value plain honesty, including many autistic people, it feels like lying, and they may wonder what else isn’t true.

> **“When I say I love a present, I mean I love that you thought of me.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Find something true and kind to say, like “You remembered I like blue. Thank you.” Honest people can use this too, and nobody has to lie.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=white-lie

17 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

"How are you?" when nobody wants a full answer

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A colleague says "How are you?" while walking past, and doesn't stop for the answer.

THE LOGIC

1. It's a greeting that happens to be shaped like a question
2. Its job is to say "hello, I see you"
3. A short answer completes the greeting
4. The full answer is for another time and another person

IT'S LIKE

A *nod across the room.*

WHY IT FITS

Lots of everyday phrases are rituals whose meaning is in the act, not the words. "How are you?" in passing works like a wave.

THE OTHER SIDE

Literal listeners answer honestly and then feel brushed off. People going through something hard can find the ritual lonely.

> **"When I say 'How are you?' in passing, I mean hello. If I really want to know, I'll stop and ask."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Answer the ritual with the ritual. "Good, thanks, you?" Save the real answer for people who stop, sit down or ask twice.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=how-are-you

18 SOCIAL RULES · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A goodbye that takes half an hour

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"We'd better go," someone says, and then talks on the doorstep for another thirty minutes.

THE LOGIC

1. Leaving can feel like ending the closeness
2. A slow goodbye winds it down gently
3. It says "I enjoyed this and I don't want it to end"
4. It's a landing, not a crash

IT'S LIKE

A *plane taxiing after it lands, rather than stopping dead on the runway.*

WHY IT FITS

Many families and friendships show warmth by stretching the goodbye. Leaving fast can feel abrupt to them, like the visit didn't matter.

THE OTHER SIDE

For someone who is already out of energy, every extra minute on the doorstep is time they don't have. Children and tired partners may be waiting in the car.

> **"The long goodbye is my way of saying I loved this. I'll try to start it earlier."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Start the goodbye ten minutes earlier. Agree a family signal that means "It's time, let's say our last bits."

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=long-goodbye

19 SOCIAL RULES · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Fine all day, then falling apart at home

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

At school or work everyone says they're fine. At home, they melt down, go silent or snap.

THE LOGIC

1. Fitting in all day takes effort that doesn't show
2. The effort is held in until it is safe to stop
3. Home feels safe, so the holding lets go
4. The crash at home shows home is trusted

IT'S LIKE

Holding your breath underwater and gasping at the surface.

WHY IT FITS

Research with autistic adults describes "camouflaging", working hard to appear like everyone else, often followed by exhaustion. Long stretches of it are linked with autistic burnout. Children and adults who aren't autistic can do a version of this too.

THE OTHER SIDE

The family gets the hardest part of the day, which can feel unfair and confusing, especially when teachers or colleagues see none of it.

> **"I hold it together all day. Home is where I can finally stop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Build in a quiet landing time after arriving home, with no questions for the first half hour. Tell school or work what home sees, so the load can be lightened there too.
>
> WITH CARE Falling apart at home can still land hard on the people there. Once settled, a few words like "that wasn't about you" help them carry it.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=mask-crash

SECTION 5

Work and school

Written instructions, "why?", deadlines, calls, meetings and feedback.

Deadlines, meetings and feedback come with unwritten rules, and people bring different ones to the same room. These pages look at asking for things in writing, starting late, agreeing in the meeting and disagreeing afterwards, and wrapping criticism in praise.

20 Asking for instructions in writing 33

21 Doing everything at the last minute 34

22 Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterwards 35

23 Wrapping criticism in praise 36



Asking for instructions in writing

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

After a spoken briefing, someone asks, “Could you send that in an email?”

THE LOGIC

1. Spoken words vanish as they’re said
2. Holding them in mind while doing the task splits attention
3. Written steps can be checked again
4. Asking for writing means wanting to get it right

IT’S LIKE

A *recipe card rather than a cook calling instructions from the next room.*

WHY IT FITS

Many people with ADHD, many autistic people and many people with dyslexia find spoken instructions hard to hold while working. Executive functions like working memory differ a lot between people. Writing turns memory into something reliable.

THE OTHER SIDE

The manager may feel it’s extra work, or hear it as distrust of what they said.

> **“I ask for it in writing so I get it right first time. I trust what we agreed.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP After a chat, the person can send a two-line summary, such as “So I’m doing X by Friday. Right?” The manager just replies “Yes.”



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=written-please

Doing everything at the last minute

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The work had a month. It gets done the night before.

THE LOGIC

1. Interest and urgency switch the engine on
2. A far-off deadline doesn't
3. The deadline arriving finally turns on the engine
4. Late work can be a starting problem, not a caring problem

IT'S LIKE

A *car that only starts when you roll it down a hill.*

WHY IT FITS

For many people with ADHD, getting started depends on interest, novelty or urgency more than importance. Researchers link this to how motivation and self-control work in ADHD. It has nothing to do with laziness.

THE OTHER SIDE

Colleagues or family may carry the stress of not knowing whether it will be done, or end up covering for it.

> **"I care about this. My brain only starts when it's urgent, so I'm building in early deadlines."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Set fake earlier deadlines with someone else, work alongside someone (body doubling), or break the first step down to five minutes.
>
> WITH CARE When last-minute work pushes stress onto others, the fair move is an earlier check-in they can count on.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

`spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-minute`

22 WORK AND SCHOOL · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterwards

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A colleague nods along in the meeting, then tells the boss privately they think it won't work.

THE LOGIC

1. Disagreeing in public can make people defend their idea harder
2. A quiet word later lets them change their mind without losing face
3. The point gets through more often that way
4. It's a strategy for being heard

IT'S LIKE

Telling someone privately there's spinach in their teeth, not announcing it.

WHY IT FITS

Many people raise disagreement privately because it's more likely to be heard. It protects the relationship and the other person's dignity.

THE OTHER SIDE

To people who value saying things openly, it can look dishonest, and they may feel the meeting was a performance.

> **"I raised it afterwards so it would be heard. I wasn't going behind anyone's back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Teams can offer both routes. "Say it now, or message me after." Quiet disagreers can say "I've a different view, I'll send it after."

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=disagree-later

Wrapping criticism in praise

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A manager says “Great energy! The report needs a full rewrite. Lovely formatting!”

THE LOGIC

1. Criticism on its own can make people defensive
2. Praise around it keeps the listener open
3. Open ears take in the fix
4. The praise is part of how the message gets delivered

IT’S LIKE

A *spoonful of sugar with medicine.*

WHY IT FITS

Many people soften feedback to protect the relationship and keep the listener able to hear it.

THE OTHER SIDE

Literal listeners may miss the middle part entirely, or stop trusting the praise because it seems to come before bad news.

> **“I meant the praise, and the change is important too.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Ask straight out, “What’s the one thing I should change?” Givers can say the fix clearly, then one true good thing.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=feedback-sandwich

SECTION 6

Family and partners

Love shown in deeds, going quiet, chasing, reassurance and advice.

Close to home, a reaction lands harder, because it comes from someone who matters. Going quiet, asking again and giving advice nobody asked for each have a logic, and each has another side. These pages hold both.

24 Showing love by doing, not saying 38

25 Going quiet in an argument 39

26 Asking for reassurance again and again 40

27 “If you loved me, you’d know what’s wrong” 41

28 A parent giving advice nobody asked for 42



Showing love by doing, not saying

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

One partner rarely says “I love you” but fixes the bike, fills the car and makes the lunches.

THE LOGIC

1. Love can be said or done
2. For some people doing feels truer than saying
3. Fixing the bike is the message
4. The words are in the action

IT’S LIKE

Two languages for the same sentence.

WHY IT FITS

People show care in different ways. Some, including many autistic people, find practical help a clearer and more honest way to show love than words.

THE OTHER SIDE

A partner who hears love mainly in words may feel unloved, even while surrounded by kind acts.

> **“Fixing your bike was me saying I love you.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree one word and one deed. The doer says “I love you” on the way out, and the talker notices the deeds out loud.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=love-in-deeds

Going quiet in an argument

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

In the middle of a row, one person stops answering and stares at the floor.

THE LOGIC

1. A fast argument floods the body
2. A flooded brain struggles to find good words
3. Silence stops bad words getting out
4. Going quiet is braking, not punishing

IT'S LIKE

Pulling over in heavy rain until you can see the road again.

WHY IT FITS

Long-running research on couples found that arguments with more negative than positive moments went with more trouble later. Pausing when overwhelmed can stop a row turning more negative.

THE OTHER SIDE

Silence can feel like being shut out or punished. For someone who needs to settle things to calm down, it can be frightening.

> **"I'm going quiet so I don't say something I don't mean. I'll come back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Say a return time. "I need twenty minutes. I'll come back at eight." Then come back at eight.
>
> WITH CARE Silence with no return time can feel like being abandoned. Naming when you'll come back is what makes the pause fair.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=quiet-in-fight

26 FAMILY AND PARTNERS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Asking for reassurance again and again

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

"Are you sure you're not angry with me?" for the fourth time tonight.

THE LOGIC

1. Doubt feels like danger
2. Reassurance turns the alarm off for a moment
3. The alarm comes back
4. Asking again is trying to turn it off again

IT'S LIKE

Going back to check the front door is locked.

WHY IT FITS

Uncertainty can feel unbearable, especially with anxiety or with obsessive worries. Asking is an understandable way to get relief, even if the relief doesn't last.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person answering can feel worn out, or that their word isn't trusted. Answering again and again can also keep the loop going.

> **"I know you said it. My worry keeps coming back, and asking turns it down for a bit."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree a kind limit together. Answer once clearly, then "I said it, and I meant it," plus something calming to do together. If the worry runs your days, a GP or therapist can help.
>
> WITH CARE Endless reassurance can tire the other person out and keep the worry looping. A limit agreed together is kinder for both.

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=reassurance

“If you loved me, you’d know what’s wrong”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone is upset and won’t say why, and seems more hurt that their partner hasn’t guessed.

THE LOGIC

1. Being understood without asking feels like proof of love
2. Having to explain feels like it spoils the proof
3. So the hint stays a hint
4. It’s a hope, not a trap

IT’S LIKE

Hoping someone notices your new haircut without being told.

WHY IT FITS

Feeling known is a deep need in close relationships. Wanting it shown without asking is very human.

THE OTHER SIDE

For many people, autistic or not, mind-reading simply isn’t possible. The guesser feels set up to fail and tested.

> **“I hoped you’d notice. I’ll tell you, and it still counts.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Agree that saying it out loud is allowed and still counts as being loved. The guesser can ask, “I can see something’s up. Tell me?”

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=you-should-know

28 FAMILY AND PARTNERS · A COMMON SOCIAL HABIT

A parent giving advice nobody asked for

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A grandparent watches you settle the baby and says, “In my day we did it like this.”

THE LOGIC

1. Advice is how some people show care
2. They learned things the hard way
3. Sharing it is trying to spare you that
4. It’s love in an awkward wrapper

IT’S LIKE

Someone pressing an umbrella on you as you leave.

WHY IT FITS

For many older relatives, passing on experience is their way of staying useful and close.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person receiving it may hear “You’re doing it wrong,” and feel undermined, especially when tired.

> **“Thanks. I’ve got this, and I’ll ask you when I need you.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Give them a real job they’re good at, so their help has somewhere to go. Agree topics where you’d welcome advice.

This one online

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=unasked-advice

SECTION 7

Feelings and shutdowns

Meltdowns, shutdowns, a flat face, big reactions and needing space.

Big feelings can come out as a meltdown, a shutdown, a blank face or an outburst over a cup. None of these is a choice in the moment. These pages explain what is happening inside, and what helps afterwards.

29 A meltdown 44

30 Shutting down and going still or silent 45

31 "I don't know how I feel" 46

32 Getting upset over something "small" 47



A meltdown

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone suddenly shouts, cries, throws or bolts, in a way that looks out of proportion.

THE LOGIC

1. Input keeps coming, with noise, demands and change
2. The brain's buffer fills
3. When it overflows, control goes
4. A meltdown is an overflow, not a tantrum to get something

IT'S LIKE

A sink overflowing when the tap stays on.

WHY IT FITS

Autistic young people describe meltdowns as different from tantrums. They come from overload rather than from wanting something, and they are not chosen. Children and adults can both have them.

THE OTHER SIDE

People nearby may feel frightened, embarrassed or blamed, and may not know what to do.

> **"It was too much at once. I couldn't stop it, and I'm sorry it was scary."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP During one, use fewer words, less noise and more space, with safety first. Afterwards, rest, then have a calm talk about early warning signs.
>
> WITH CARE If anyone gets hurt, safety comes first, for everyone. Afterwards, a repair and a plan for next time help both people.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=meltdown

30 FEELINGS AND SHUTDOWNS · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Shutting down and going still or silent

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone stops talking, stares, and doesn't respond to questions.

THE LOGIC

1. Overload builds up
2. The system switches off what isn't essential
3. Speech is often one of the first things to go
4. Stillness is the system protecting itself

IT'S LIKE

A *computer starting in safe mode.*

WHY IT FITS

Autistic people describe shutdowns as an inward response to overload, where talking or moving becomes hard. It isn't sulking and it isn't a choice.

THE OTHER SIDE

Those nearby may feel ignored, frightened, or that they caused it.

> **"When I go quiet like that, I can't talk yet. I'll come back."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Offer yes/no questions, a nod, or writing instead of talking. A quiet space and time help most.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=shutdown

“I don’t know how I feel”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Asked how they feel, someone says “I don’t know” and seems stuck.

THE LOGIC

1. Feelings start as signals in the body
2. Some people find those signals hard to read
3. No clear signal means no clear word
4. “I don’t know” is an honest answer

IT’S LIKE

A *radio stuck between two stations.*

WHY IT FITS

Researchers call difficulty naming feelings alexithymia. It’s common in autistic people, and plenty of others have it too. Feelings are linked to body signals, which some people read less clearly.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person asking may think they’re being shut out, or that the other person doesn’t want to share.

> **“I really don’t know yet. Ask me about my body. Am I tired, tense or hungry?”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Ask simpler questions about the body, such as “More tired or more annoyed?” and “Space or company?” Give it time and come back later.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=dont-know-feeling

Getting upset over something "small"

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

After a long day, a cup left on the side leads to an outburst.

THE LOGIC

1. Stress adds up all day
2. Each thing fills a glass a little more
3. The small thing is the last drop
4. The spill is the whole glass, not just the drop

IT'S LIKE

The straw that broke the camel's back.

WHY IT FITS

Stress builds up and makes small things feel bigger. The reaction belongs to the whole day.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person who left the cup gets the whole glass poured on them and feels it was unfair.

> **"It's not just the cup. It's been a heavy day, and that was the last drop."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Name the full glass early, with "I'm nearly full today." Afterwards, apologise for the size and talk about the cup separately.
>
> WITH CARE The person who did the small thing shouldn't carry the whole day. A repair afterwards matters.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-straw

SECTION 8

Routines and special interests

Same food, my mug, long talks about an interest, stopping a task.

Sameness and deep interests are ways of saving energy and finding joy. From outside they can look rigid or one-sided. These pages show the logic, and a way to meet in the middle.

33 Eating the same food every day 49

34 Talking for a long time about one interest 50



Eating the same food every day

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Someone eats the same lunch every day and turns down anything new.

THE LOGIC

1. Every new food is a small gamble
2. A known food is a sure thing
3. Sure things save energy for the rest of the day
4. Sameness is efficiency

IT'S LIKE

A *favourite mug. Any mug holds tea, but this one is right.*

WHY IT FITS

Taste, texture and smell are strong for some people, including many autistic people. A known food removes an unpleasant surprise and frees energy for other things.

THE OTHER SIDE

The cook may feel their effort is refused, and families can worry about health or social meals.

> **"I eat this because it's safe and easy for me. It says nothing about your cooking."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Keep a "safe" option on the table alongside anything new. Try new food on low-pressure days, one small taste at a time.



This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=same-food

34 ROUTINES AND SPECIAL INTERESTS · COMMON FOR MANY NEURODIVERGENT PEOPLE

Talking for a long time about one interest

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Asked one question about trains, someone talks for twenty minutes.

THE LOGIC

1. The interest is where they feel most themselves
2. Sharing it is sharing themselves
3. Detail is the gift
4. A long explanation is an invitation in

IT'S LIKE

Showing someone round your garden, bed by bed.

WHY IT FITS

For many autistic people, special interests bring real joy and are linked with wellbeing. Sharing them is a way of connecting.

THE OTHER SIDE

The listener may feel lost, trapped, or that they can't get a word in.

> **"When I go on about this, I'm sharing something I love with you. Tell me if you need a break."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Start with a five-minute version and ask "Want more?" Listeners can say "Tell me the best bit" or "Can we pause and come back?"



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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=info-dump

SECTION 9

Different rulebooks

Driving, tipping, "on time", loud families, plain feedback and texting: habits learned in different places.

A lot of friction comes from people following different rulebooks, each sure theirs is normal. What "seven o'clock" means, how loud a family dinner gets, how plainly feedback is given and whether a full stop in a text is cross are all learned in a particular place, family or generation.

35 Different ideas of "on time" 52

36 A family that talks loudly and over each other 53

37 Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft 54

38 Texting habits that seem cold or odd 55



35 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Different ideas of “on time”

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

One person arrives at 7 sharp for a 7 o’clock dinner; the other arrives at 7.40 and thinks that’s on time.

THE LOGIC

1. “Seven o’clock” is read through a local rule
2. In some families and places it means seven exactly; in others it means “from seven”
3. Each person turns up at the time their rule says is polite
4. Neither is being careless; they’re reading the same words differently

IT’S LIKE

A *recipe that says “a pinch”, when everyone’s pinch is different.*

WHY IT FITS

How strictly a time is kept varies between cultures, families, workplaces and kinds of event. A party, a dinner and a train each have different unwritten rules.

THE OTHER SIDE

The person who arrived “on time” may have waited, felt unimportant, or had food go cold.

> **“Where I grew up, seven meant come from seven. I’ll check what you mean next time.”**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Say which kind of time you mean, such as “Seven sharp, the table is booked” or “Any time after seven.”

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=on-time-means

A family that talks loudly and over each other

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

At a partner's family dinner, everyone talks at once, loudly, and it sounds like arguing.

THE LOGIC

1. Every family has its own volume and turn-taking rules
2. In some homes talking over each other means everyone is engaged
3. Loud can mean warm and lively
4. The noise is their normal, not a fight

IT'S LIKE

A *busy market where the shouting is how business gets done.*

WHY IT FITS

Families and cultures differ in how loud and overlapping conversation is. In some, jumping in shows you're interested; in others, waiting your turn shows respect.

THE OTHER SIDE

Someone from a quieter home may feel overwhelmed, unable to get a word in, or think everyone is cross.

> **"We're not arguing. This is just how my family talks."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP The quieter person can take short breaks or ask a direct question to get a turn. The family can pause to ask them in by name.

This one online

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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=loud-family

37 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A new colleague says "This is wrong" in a meeting. Another says "Maybe we could think about it" and means "This is wrong."

THE LOGIC

1. How directly people give feedback is learned at home, at school and at work
2. In some workplaces plain words show respect and trust
3. In others, softer words protect the relationship
4. Each person is being polite by the rules they learned

IT'S LIKE

Two people using different units, miles and kilometres, for the same distance.

WHY IT FITS

Workplaces and cultures differ in how bluntly disagreement is expressed. Neither style is wrong, but mixing them without knowing causes a lot of hurt.

THE OTHER SIDE

The softer speaker may feel attacked by plain words; the plainer speaker may feel misled when soft words hid a real problem.

> **"Where I trained, we say it straight so it's quick to fix. Tell me if you'd like it gentler."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Ask early, "How do you like feedback, straight or with some cushioning?" Agree a style for the team.



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spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=direct-culture

38 DIFFERENT RULEBOOKS · SOMETHING ANYONE CAN DO

Texting habits that seem cold or odd

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A parent replies "OK." with a full stop; a teenager reads anger. Or an older relative phones when a text would do.

THE LOGIC

1. Texting habits are learned in a particular time and group
2. For some, a full stop is just how a sentence ends; for others it signals annoyance
3. Phoning can mean care for one person and intrusion for another
4. Each person is writing in the style they learned

IT'S LIKE

Handwriting, neat or messy. It isn't about how they feel about you.

WHY IT FITS

Different age groups and friendship groups use punctuation, emojis and calls differently. The same message can carry different tones to different readers.

THE OTHER SIDE

The reader may feel snubbed, scolded or interrupted, and worry about what was meant.

> **"My full stop isn't cross. It's just how I write."**
>
> ONE SMALL STEP Talk about it once, on a calm day. What does "OK." mean to each of you? Agree when to call and when to text.

This one online

Free, with more pictures to choose from.

spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=text-generations

Build your own

For a reaction this guide doesn't cover, your own or someone else's. It works best on a calm day, and better still with the other person.

1. **What it looks like.** Camera words only. What would a camera see or hear?
2. **The logic.** Three or four steps. Start with a plain fact about how things work.
3. **It's like.** Something everyday that works the same way inside.
4. **Why it fits.** What makes it reasonable, said fairly.
5. **The other side.** What might the other person feel or need?
6. **One sentence and one step.** Words to say, and something small to try this week.

Watch for verdict words. "Rude", "lazy", "selfish" and "dramatic" are guesses about a person. Swap them for what a camera would see, and the logic has room to show itself. If a step needs "because they're like that", keep asking why.

Online, it makes a card. The website's "Build your own" turns your six parts into a card you can save or share. Nothing you type is sent anywhere.

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

The reaction

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

THE LOGIC

IT'S LIKE

WHY IT FITS

THE OTHER SIDE

ONE SENTENCE AND ONE STEP

Find it fast

Every situation in this guide, A to Z.

A family that talks loudly and over each other 53

A goodbye that takes half an hour 30

A meltdown 44

A parent giving advice nobody asked for 42

A white lie about a present 28

Agreeing in the meeting, disagreeing afterwards 35

Asking for instructions in writing 33

Asking for reassurance again and again 40

Cancelling plans after a long week 18

Different ideas of “on time” 52

Doing everything at the last minute 34

Eating the same food every day 49

Feedback at work that sounds harsh, or too soft 54

Fine all day, then falling apart at home 31

Getting upset over something “small” 47

Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute 10

Giving blunt, direct feedback 21

Going quiet in an argument 39

Hinting instead of asking 23

“How are you?” when nobody wants a full answer 29

“I don’t know how I feel” 46

“If you loved me, you’d know what’s wrong” 41

Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye 15

"Let's get coffee sometime" with no date 12
"Maybe" that means no 13
Needing time alone after seeing people 19
Not looking at you while listening 25
Running late again, despite really caring 11
Saying "I'm fine" when you're not 22
Showing love by doing, not saying 38
Shutting down and going still or silent 45
Small talk about the weather 27
Snapping when hungry or tired 17
Talking for a long time about one interest 50
Teasing as a sign of affection 24
Texting habits that seem cold or odd 55
Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people 16
Wrapping criticism in praise 36

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- **The full guide.** How the lens works, the research behind it, and when logic isn't an excuse.

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Research notes

The 23 studies and essays these pages lean on, in short, with the situations that use them. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found and how strong the finding is, is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Barkley, R. A. (1997). *Behavioral inhibition, sustained attention, and executive functions: Constructing a unifying theory of ADHD. Running late again, despite really caring* (11), *Asking for instructions in writing* (33), *Doing everything at the last minute* (34)

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Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective. Giving blunt, direct feedback* (21)

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Dunn, W. (1997). *The impact of sensory processing abilities on the daily lives of young children and their families: A conceptual model. Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people* (16)

Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014). *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights? Snapping when hungry or tired* (17)

Gottman, J. M., & Levenson, R. W. (1992). *Marital processes predictive of later dissolution: Behavior, physiology, and health. Going quiet in an argument* (39)

Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018). *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults. Talking for a long time about one interest* (50)

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Levine, E. E., & Schweitzer, M. E. (2015). *Prosocial lies: When deception breeds trust.* *A white lie about a present* (28)

MacCormack, J. K., & Lindquist, K. A. (2018). *Feeling hangry? When hunger is conceptualized as emotion.* *Snapping when hungry or tired* (17)

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Miserandino, C. (2003). *The spoon theory.* *Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye* (15)

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* *Talking for a long time about one interest* (50)

Pellicano, E., & Burr, D. (2012). *When the world becomes 'too real': a Bayesian explanation of autistic perception.* *Getting upset when a plan changes at the last minute* (10), *Wearing headphones or earplugs around other people* (16)

Phung, J., Penner, M., Pirlot, C., & Welch, C. (2021). *What I wish you knew: Insights on burnout, inertia, meltdown, and shutdown from autistic youth.* *A meltdown* (44), *Shutting down and going still or silent* (45)

Pinker, S., Nowak, M. A., & Lee, J. J. (2008). *The logic of indirect speech.* *"Let's get coffee sometime" with no date* (12), *"Maybe" that means no* (13), *Hinting instead of asking* (23)

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* *Leaving a party early, without a long goodbye* (15), *Needing time alone after seeing people* (19), *Fine all day, then falling apart at home* (31)

Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014). *Social interactions and well-being: The surprising power of weak ties.* *Small talk about the weather* (27)

Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017). *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* *Not looking at you while listening* (25)

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